

To add fuel to the fire, the institution intends under the prime minister's Street Lighting National Programme (SLNP) for next 4-5 years to bring in investment to the tune of 80,000 million rupees by 2024 by covering the entire rural India. EESL expects that more than 30 million LED streetlights would be retrofitted/installed by it. In fact, if a report by the Electric Lamp and Component Manufacturers Association is to be believed, the LED industry in India now makes 80 percent of the total lightings required.

In order to make most of this opportunity, both for the nation and local manufacturers of LED lights in India, the government in the recent Budget announced that the BCD on inputs and parts of LED lights or fixtures including LED lamps has been revised to 10 percent with effect from February 2021.

It is to be noted here that the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) had announced random testing of LED lights and control gears for LED products imported in India in September 2020. Interestingly, China is among the world's largest exporters of LED lights and raw materials required for making LED lights. During 2014-15, India imported LED lighting products under HS code 9405 worth US\$ 222.3 million. China was the largest supplier with a share of 84.76 percent, followed by Republic of Korea with 5.43 percent, and Hong Kong with 2.4 percent.

Lithium-ion batteries: Powering more than just electric vehicles

There is no doubt in the fact that the electric vehicle (EV) industry is going to be one of the biggest in the years to come and the increased adoption of lithium-ion batteries will definitely lead to a lot of business opportunities. The electric vehicle market in India is expected to hit over 6.3 million unit mark per annum by 2027, according to a report by India Energy Storage Alliance (IESA). The same stood at only 0.38 million units in 2019-20, and the EV battery market stood at 5.4GWh during the year.

The government of India, keeping India's increasing adoption of EVs in mind, has made 2.5 percent BCD man-

datory on inputs, parts, and subparts (other than PCBA and Li-ion cell) for manufacture of lithium-ion battery and battery packs.

JMK Research estimates the annual lithium-ion battery market in India to increase at a CAGR of 37.5 percent to reach 132GWh in 2030. Similarly, cumulative lithium-ion battery market size is estimated to increase from 2.9GWh in 2018 to about 800GWh by 2030.

The move by the government of India may not only encourage increased localised production of these batteries by giving headroom to local manufacturers competing against the foreign ones but might also encourage the recycling of lithium-ion batteries as a sector. More importantly, lithium-ion batteries have been powering portable electronics like laptops and cell phones for over a decade now.

Solar power: Going green to save environment and increase

Solar power has long been touted as one the best alternatives to non-recyclable sources of energy. It, in fact, is also a big business opportunity in the world. A report by Research and Markets forecasts that the solar inverter market in India is projected to grow at a CAGR of over 20.3 percent from 2019 to 2025. The commercial segment is estimated to exhibit the highest growth rate during the forecast period.

Among system types, on-grid systems dominated the India solar inverter market share in 2018 owing to huge adoption across different applications. Government initiatives, as per the report, such as the Smart City project, development of solar parks, and solar energy subsidy scheme, would further accelerate the adoption of solar installations across the residential and commercial segments.

The government, during the 2021 Budget, has mandated 20 percent BCD on solar inverters. Known as the heart of a solar power system, solar inverters used to attract only five percent BCD till now. The new amendment is effective from first of February 2021.

Similarly, solar lanterns or solar lamps, which sell like hot cakes in remote areas and rural India, also



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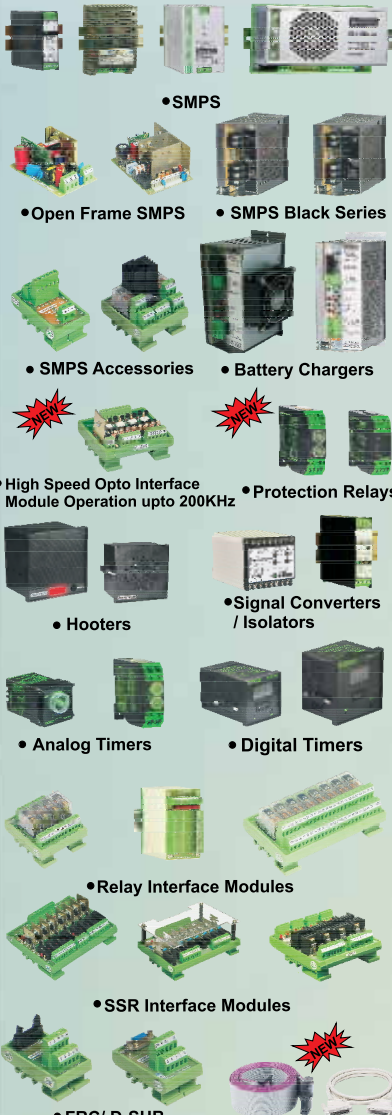
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